

The Medium — A Foundational Theory of Reality

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2026

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Out of empty chaos all of creation becomes.

That sentence is the theory. Everything that follows is the attempt to say it precisely.

1 The Foundational Claim

The framework rests on a single foundational claim from which everything else follows:

The Medium always is and always was. It has no beginning and no end. It exists outside of any temporal framework. Intrinsic distinction is an eternal property of the Medium — not an event that occurred but a condition that always obtains. The structure we observe is not the result of something that happened. It is the expression of what the Medium always is.

This claim does three things at once.

It eliminates the need for a trigger. The question of what initiated the universe only arises if time is assumed to be primitive. If the Medium always is and always was, there is no before and no initiation. The trigger problem dissolves not by answering it but by identifying it as a consequence of a false assumption.

It eliminates time as a primitive. The Medium exists outside of time. What physics calls time is not a property of the substrate. It is an experience of observers embedded within the differentiated structure of the Medium — a consequence of transition, not a fundamental feature of reality.

It reframes differentiation. The emergence of structure from the Medium is not a process that started. It is a condition that always obtains. The ground state and the differentiated state coexist within the Medium eternally, because intrinsic distinction — ι — is eternal, and time does not apply to it.

2 The Stochastic Character of the Medium

Before the formal axioms are introduced, the nature of the Medium's ground state requires precise characterization. That characterization is stochastic — and the stochastic framing is not incidental. It is the most exact description available of what the Medium is prior to the activation of intrinsic distinction.

2.1 The Ground State as Fully Random Autonomous Stochastic System

The Medium at its ground state is a fully autonomous stochastic system. It requires no inputs, no external cause, no temporal framework, and no governing distribution. Its randomness is not randomness within a framework — it is randomness without framework. No outcome is privileged over any other. Non-existence holds no advantage over existence. Existence holds no advantage over non-existence.

This is not chaos. Chaos retains structure. The ground state of the Medium precedes structure entirely. It is the absolute suspension of all constraint, including constraints upon randomness itself. It is meta-randomness — randomness that is random about its own nature.

2.2 What Fully Random Stochastic Nothingness Implies

In a fully random autonomous system of infinite extent with no preferred states, every possible configuration has nonzero probability. This has a consequence that is not intuitive but is mathematically unavoidable:

In an infinite substrate with fully random stochastic character and no privileged states, every possible fluctuation — including the emergence of ordered, structured, low-entropy configurations — is not merely possible but necessary as a feature of the distribution itself.

The universe is not something that happened against the odds. It is a necessary expression of a substrate that has no mechanism for suppressing any possibility.

2.3 The Relationship Between Stochastic Character and ι

The stochastic character of the Medium describes the nature of the ground state. Intrinsic distinction — ι — describes the property that makes the ground state generative rather than merely static. The relationship is precise:

- Stochastic character describes what the ground state *is*
- ι describes what makes the ground state capable of producing structure
- Manifestation V is the stochastic event — the actualization of a possibility
- Structure formation at c is what a successful manifestation produces

3 Axioms and Primitives

The formal definitions follow directly from the foundational claim and the stochastic characterization of the ground state. Several are marked provisional. Open questions are named precisely and carried explicitly as objects of investigation.

3.1 Axiom I — The Eternal Medium

The Medium always is and always was. It has no beginning, no end, and no external cause.

$$\nexists t_0 : M \text{ begins at } t_0 \quad \nexists t_1 : M \text{ ends at } t_1 \quad (1)$$

Status: Axiomatic.

3.2 Axiom II — Intrinsic Distinction and the Unity of V

The Medium possesses intrinsic distinction, denoted ι . It is not an operator, not a function, not a process. It is the one irreducible property of the thing that simply is — the capacity of the undifferentiated to give rise to the differentiated.

The activation of ι at a location in a transition is denoted V . V is either present or absent. When present, it is identical at every location and every transition — no magnitude, no internal structure, no degrees. A quantity that is indivisible, identical at every occurrence, and admitting no degrees has exactly one formal representation:

$$V \equiv 1 \tag{2}$$

V is dimensionless unity

This is not V being assigned a value. It is V being recognized as what it is. The Medium is pre-dimensional. No units exist at the substrate level. $V \equiv 1$ is a pure number — the simplest non-trivial element of the substrate's arithmetic.

Status: Axiomatic. Nature of ι under investigation.

3.3 Axiom III — Locality Emergence

Location is not a primitive of the Medium. It does not exist prior to differentiation. Location is produced when differentiation, propagating at the limit c , gives rise to self-sustaining structure. Before this condition is met, the concepts of here and there, near and far, position and distance are genuinely absent — not suppressed but nonexistent.

Status: Axiomatic.

3.4 Primitive I — The Medium (Post-Locality)

$$M = \{x \mid x \text{ is a location}\} \tag{3}$$

Status: Provisional — post-locality approximation only.

3.5 Primitive II — The Population Function

With $V \equiv 1$, the population function ϕ maps each location to the presence or absence of manifestation. The Medium is formally a binary field over its locations.

$$\phi : M \rightarrow \{0, 1\} \tag{4}$$

$$\phi(x) = 1 \text{ if manifestation has occurred at } x, \quad 0 \text{ otherwise} \tag{5}$$

Both 0 and 1 are dimensionless. The substrate has no units.

Status: Current.

3.6 Primitive III — The Manifestation Probability

Manifestation is a binary stochastic event. At any transition t , a location x either manifests or it does not. The probability $p(x)$ is a Bernoulli parameter over the binary field.

$$\text{manifestation}(x, t) \in \{0, 1\} \quad (6)$$

$$p(x) = \Pr(\phi(x) = 1), \quad p : M \rightarrow [0, 1] \quad (7)$$

Status: Current.

3.7 Primitive IV — Transition

Time is not a primitive of this framework. What physics describes as temporal evolution is, at the level of the Medium, transition — a change from one binary field state to another. The transition index t is a dimensionless label, not a clock. No duration is implied.

$$M_t \rightarrow M_{t+1} \quad (8)$$

Status: Current.

3.8 Primitive V — The Propagation Limit

The Medium imposes a fundamental constraint on how rapidly the activation of ι can propagate across a transition. This limit is denoted c . At the substrate level c is dimensionless — a bound on the rate of change of the binary field, not a velocity. What physics calls the speed of light is the projection of this dimensionless bound into the observer's dimensional framework.

$$|\phi_{t+1}(x) - \phi_t(x)| \leq c \quad (\text{dimensionless}) \quad (9)$$

Status: Provisional.

3.9 Primitive VI — The Structure Formation Condition

A self-sustaining structure forms when propagation reaches the limit exactly. This is the threshold at which locality is born.

$$|\phi_{t+1}(x) - \phi_t(x)| = c \tag{10}$$

Status: Provisional.

4 Physics as Projection

The Medium is pre-dimensional. It has no meters, no seconds, no kilograms. $V \equiv 1$ is a pure number. The binary field ϕ is dimensionless. The propagation limit c is a dimensionless transition bound. The transition index t is a dimensionless label. Nothing in the substrate description carries units of any kind.

Dimensions do not exist in the Medium. They are invented by observers.

An observer is a self-sustaining structure in the binary field ϕ — a stable pattern that persists across transitions. Such a structure is embedded in the differentiated region it constitutes. It cannot perceive the substrate directly. It perceives only the relationships between structures like itself, mediated by the propagation of manifestation events across the field. To describe those relationships, it constructs a coordinate system — a framework of units and dimensions that makes the relationships tractable.

That coordinate system is not a discovery about the substrate. It is a construction of the observer. The dimensions of physics — length, time, mass, charge, temperature — are categories the observer imposes on what it measures. They have no counterpart in the substrate.

This has a precise consequence:

Every dimensional quantity in physics — every constant, every observable, every equation — is a projection of a dimensionless substrate relationship onto the observer’s dimensional coordinate system. Physics, correctly understood from the point of view of the Medium, is the complete and consistent description of those projections. It is not wrong. It is a perfect map of the shadow. It is not a description of the substrate that casts it.

4.1 The Projection Boundary

The boundary between the substrate and the observer’s framework is precise. It is the boundary between the dimensionless and the dimensional. Everything on the substrate side is a pure number or a binary value. Everything on the observer side carries units.

This boundary is a structural feature of the framework, not a gap in it. The Medium framework identifies the boundary precisely and locates every quantity of physics on the correct side of it.

The right column of Table 1 is the language of physics. The left column is the language of the Medium. The table is not a set of results. It is a research program. Each row

Table 1: Substrate quantities and their observer projections. Each row is a derivation target.

Substrate (dimensionless)	Observer projection (dimensional)
$V \equiv 1$ (pure number)	h [action] — Planck’s constant
c (transition rate bound)	c [length/time] — speed of light
$\phi(x) \in \{0, 1\}$ (binary)	quantum amplitude, probability
t (transition index)	time [seconds]
structure formation condition	spacetime geometry
binary field entropy	thermodynamic entropy [J/K]
propagation pattern density	energy, mass [J, kg]
ι (intrinsic distinction)	[to be derived]

identifies a correspondence that must be formally derived. Version 0.3 does not carry out these derivations. It names them precisely and establishes the framework within which they can be pursued.

4.2 What Projection Means for Planck’s Constant

The first row of Table 1 is the most immediate. $V \equiv 1$ at the substrate level. Planck’s constant h appears at the observer level as the dimensional expression of that same event.

The relationship is not an equation between equals. V does not *become* h . h is what an observer with a dimensional coordinate system measures when a manifestation event V occurs.

$$\text{Substrate: } V \equiv 1 \quad (\text{dimensionless}) \quad (11)$$

$$\text{Observer: } h = \text{proj}(V) \quad (\text{units of action, observer-dependent}) \quad (12)$$

The numerical value of h in any given unit system encodes the relationship between the observer’s unit definitions and the substrate’s natural scale. It is not a fact about the substrate. It is a fact about the observer.

An open question is carried explicitly: why does the projection of V carry units of action specifically? The answer requires a formal account of how the observer’s dimensional categories emerge from the structure of sustained binary field configurations. That derivation is a primary target for future development.

4.3 What Projection Means for the Speed of Light

The propagation limit c is dimensionless at the substrate level — a pure bound on binary field transition rates. The observer, embedded in a structure that extends across space and time, measures propagation in units of length per unit time. The dimensionless bound is projected into this framework and appears as a velocity.

Setting $c = 1$ in physics — standard in relativistic calculations — is the partial recovery of the substrate’s natural description. It removes one layer of the observer’s unit construction. The Medium framework identifies why that recovery works: the substrate never had the units to begin with.

4.4 The General Principle

The pattern is the same in every row of Table 1. A dimensionless substrate relationship is measured by an observer whose coordinate system assigns dimensions to everything it touches. The dimensional quantity that results is real and useful — it correctly describes the structure of the observer’s world. But it carries information about the observer’s measurement framework that is absent from the substrate.

The presence of dimensional constants in the equations of physics — h , c , G , k — is the signature of this projection. Each constant marks a place where the observer’s dimensional framework has been imposed on a substrate relationship that has none. In the substrate’s own arithmetic, those constants do not appear. The equations are clean.

The program implied by Table 1 is the following: for each row, derive the dimensional form of the observer quantity from the substrate quantity and a formal account of the projection boundary. If that program succeeds, every fundamental constant of physics will have been given a substrate derivation — and the mystery of their values will have been resolved, not by finding deeper constants, but by understanding that they were never fundamental to begin with.

Status: The projection boundary and its general principle are proposed as a structural feature of the framework. The correspondence table is a research program, not a set of results. Individual derivations are deferred to future versions.

5 The Entropic Arc

The relationship between the stochastic ground state of the Medium and the thermodynamic concept of entropy yields a consequence that bears directly on one of the deepest unsolved problems in the current understanding of physical reality.

5.1 The Ground State as Maximum Entropy

The ground state of the Medium — fully random, fully undifferentiated, $\phi = 0$ almost everywhere — is a maximum entropy state. Every configuration of the binary field is equally probable.

$$S = k \log W \quad \text{where } W \text{ is maximal at the ground state} \quad (13)$$

Note: S and k are observer projections; W is a dimensionless substrate count

5.2 Intrinsic Distinction as a Low Entropy Event

The activation of ι — a single location transitioning from $\phi = 0$ to $\phi = 1$ — is necessarily a minimum local entropy event. One specific binary configuration emerges from an infinite sea of equally probable arrangements.

5.3 Resolution of the Low Entropy Initial Condition Problem

The current understanding of physical reality faces a foundational problem: the universe appears to have begun in a state of extraordinarily low entropy. Nothing in the existing framework explains this.

The Medium framework resolves this without being asked. The first flip from 0 to 1 in the binary field is a low entropy event by definition — one specific outcome from the maximum entropy ground state. The initial condition is not a brute fact. It follows necessarily from Axiom II and the stochastic character of the ground state.

5.4 The Full Entropic Arc

1. The Medium obtains eternally at maximum entropy — fully random, $\phi = 0$ almost everywhere.
2. ι manifests — $V \equiv 1$ at a location — ϕ flips from 0 to 1 — minimum local entropy — maximum information.
3. Structure forms at c — locality is born — binary patterns propagate and stabilize across transitions.
4. Complexity builds — sustained low-entropy configurations emerge as eddies of order in the binary field.
5. Consciousness appears — the Medium becoming locally aware of its own stochastic origin and entropic arc.
6. The trajectory continues toward maximum entropy — ϕ returns to 0 almost everywhere.

Not a beginning and an end. A breathing.

Because the Medium is eternal and ι is its eternal property, this arc does not occur once. It occurs wherever and whenever ι manifests — infinite stochastic fluctuations, infinite arcs, each spending its low-entropy initial condition and returning to the ground. The binary field blinks into structure and blinks out again, across an infinite substrate that does not notice.

6 The Problem With Where We Started

Modern physics is extraordinary. Its achievements are beyond dispute. But the foundations were built from the wrong starting point.

Human beings began making sense of the world from the human scale. That is natural and inevitable. But it means the conceptual framework underlying physics was constructed from the middle outward, not from the beginning. We built upward toward the very large and downward toward the very small from a foundation that was never examined as a foundation. It was simply where we happened to be standing.

The consequences are visible at the edges of current theory. The two most precisely verified theories in the history of science are fundamentally incompatible with each other. The standard model requires unexplained phenomena to account for observations that do not fit the prediction. Approximately 95% of the universe by current models consists of placeholder labels for things that do not fit.

The presence of dimensional constants — h , c , G — as brute unexplained inputs to the equations of physics is itself a symptom of this displaced foundation. A theory built from the substrate would not require them. They appear precisely because physics was built from the observer's position outward, and the observer's dimensional coordinate system was baked into the language from the start. The constants are the seams where the observer's framework was stitched together without understanding what it was stitching.

7 What the Framework Proposes

7.1 The Medium

The Medium is the primitive substrate of reality — one undifferentiated thing without parts, without position, without dimension. Its character is fully random and autonomous. It is not a space containing things. It simply is, and ι is what it is.

7.2 Nothing Moves

Nothing in the Medium moves. What we experience as motion is pattern — the pattern of the binary field ϕ shifting across the substrate across transitions. What we observe as a particle is a sustained configuration in ϕ propagating at the dimensionless rate c . Nothing traveled. The pattern shifted.

7.3 On Time

Time does not exist in the Medium framework as a fundamental property. What we experience as the passage of time is the experience of transition — the change from one binary field state to another, indexed by the dimensionless label t . The arrow of time is the arrow of increasing entropy in the binary field. Both are projections of the observer's measurement framework onto substrate transitions. They are real as experiences. They are not properties of the substrate.

7.4 On Existing Physics

Once locality has been established through structure formation, the existing mathematical frameworks of physics emerge as valid descriptions of differentiated structure behavior within

their respective domains. They are not wrong. They are downstream. They are precise and consistent descriptions of the observer’s projection of the substrate. The Medium framework does not replace them. It identifies the substrate from which they project — and defines the program by which their dimensional constants can, in principle, be derived rather than assumed.

8 Unresolved Questions

These are the frontier of the framework. Each is stated precisely and carried explicitly.

The Nature of Intrinsic Distinction. What is ι ? The provisional characterization — as the property permitting local, spontaneous entropy reduction in a fully random maximum entropy binary substrate — is the central open question of the theory.

The Formal Account of the Projection Boundary. How, precisely, does an observer embedded in the binary field construct a dimensional coordinate system? What determines which dimensional categories emerge? This is the foundational question of Section 4 and the primary task for the next stage of formal development.

Why Does V Project to Action? The observer’s measurement of $V \equiv 1$ produces a quantity with units of action — energy multiplied by time. Why this dimensional combination? The answer requires a derivation of the observer’s dimensional categories from the structure of sustained binary field configurations. Until that derivation exists, the correspondence $V \equiv 1 \leftrightarrow h$ [action] is a named target, not a result.

The Derivation of Each Row of Table 1. Each correspondence in the projection table is an open derivation: c [m/s] from the dimensionless transition bound; G from structure formation geometry; thermodynamic entropy [J/K] from binary field entropy. These are the specific formal tasks the framework now names and defers.

The Status of α . The fine-structure constant $\alpha \approx 1/137$ is dimensionless. It cannot be a projection artifact in the same sense as h and c . Its status within the framework requires separate investigation.

The Structure That Emerges. What precisely is the self-sustaining binary pattern that forms when the structure formation condition is met? The formal definition of these patterns is the primary task of the next stage of development.

The Observer. The observer is herself a sustained binary configuration within ϕ , attempting to describe the substrate that produced her from within it. Every formal system contains truths it cannot prove from within itself. The Medium framework faces an analogous boundary, and acknowledges it.

9 Summary of Axioms, Primitives, and Correspondences

Table 2: Complete symbol table for version 0.3

Symbol	Definition	Status
Stochastic ground	Fully random autonomous, no distribution	v0.2
ι	Intrinsic Distinction — eternal, irreducible	Axiomatic
$V \equiv 1$	Manifestation event is dimensionless unity	New v0.3
$\phi : M \rightarrow \{0, 1\}$	Population function — binary field, dimensionless	New v0.3
Projection boundary	Dimensional quantities are observer projections of substrate	New v0.3
$h = \text{proj}(V)$	Planck’s constant is the dimensional projection of $V \equiv 1$	New v0.3
c (substrate)	Propagation limit — dimensionless transition rate bound	New v0.3
$c = \text{proj}(c)$	Speed of light is the dimensional projection of the transition bound	New v0.3
M	Eternal Medium — no beginning, no end	Axiomatic
$p(x)$	Manifestation probability — Bernoulli parameter	Current
t	Transition index — dimensionless label, not time	Current
$S = k \log W$	Boltzmann entropy — W is substrate count; S, k are projections	v0.2
$\iota \Rightarrow S_{\min}$	First distinction ($\phi : 0 \rightarrow 1$) is minimum local entropy	v0.2

10 A Personal Note

I am seventy-eight years old. I am not an academic. I have no credentials in physics or mathematics. I began this work with a question that would not leave me alone and a conviction that the question deserved a serious attempt at an answer.

I began this work knowing I may not live to see it reach its conclusions. That does not trouble me. What matters is that the ideas are documented, attributed, and made available to anyone who finds them worthy of development. If this framework contains something true it belongs to whoever can take it further. My name attached to it is enough — for the record, and for my family.

Gregor Mendel published his work on inheritance and it sat unread for decades before being recognized as foundational. The ideas belong to whoever finds them. The record belongs to their origin.

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DOI: [10.5281/zenodo.18804587](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.18804587)